

From a Skill in Her Hands to a Business of Her Own

- *Nishi's Journey from Teacher to Trainer, Entrepreneur and Mentor to Other Women*

Nishi was 51 years old and had years of experience learning, teaching and working with women. She had worked as a school teacher at Happy School in Dariaganj. Returning from the school, she found it hard to manage her family life along with her work and later joined the Multi-Disciplinary Training Centre of KVIC Gandhi Darshan, Raj Ghat, New Delhi. Here, she started teaching women to make bakery and other products like Bread, Biscuits, cookies, and pizza. Nishi could make them. She knew how to instruct others to make them. For a long time, however, she didn't know how to sell them, market them, and establish a business of her own.

She is presently part of the Golden Future Self Help Group, Dariaganj, New Delhi and has established her bakery business at home with a steadily increasing customer base, who come from a distance of 50-60 kilometres to avail her bakery products and often return to her bakery as repeat customers.

More significantly, women that she trained have established their own shops and bakeries in Delhi, Bihar, and other locations. Her career is now no longer limited to baking, however. It is about making knowledge earn money, financial independence and skills and opportunities for other women.



A time when Family Responsibilities Changed Her Path

Nishi is a resident of Dariaganj, close to the Crime Branch office, along with her husband and two daughters. She used to be a teacher at Happy School, Dariaganj. Her job as a teacher was a significant aspect of her life, but with the added burden of family responsibilities, she found it challenging to balance work and family. She decided to quit her job, but her need for work didn't go away. She enrolled at the training Centre and started to train. Women who were affiliated with the Self Help Groups also visited the centre, and it was in the centre where Nishi was introduced to the SHG network and joined Golden Future SHG two and a half years ago. Nishi started to grow her confidence in the bakery business at the centre. She could design and instruct a variety of products. However, there was one problem. She knew production. She was inexperienced in business.

Her own children were her inspiration to begin something that was her own. Their message was to them: If you can train others, why can't you build something yourself? That encouragement remained with her. Nishi began making bakery items at home. Initially, it wasn't about a big business. It was the beginning they were talking about. Gradually customers started to arrive. One became another customer. It was then that repeat customers arrived. Then larger orders. Eventually, it looked as though something started inside the home was becoming a real business.

From “I Can Make It” to “I Can Sell It”

One of the most important milestones in Nishi's entrepreneurial career was when Deepti Madam, DPM, New Delhi, invited her to the IIT Delhi Entrepreneurship Development Programme on Financial and Digital Literacy for the SHG Women Entrepreneurs scheduled at Vikas Bhawan. Nishi chose to join in. The training was great fun, and she was discovering areas of her business that she hadn't known anything about before. Prior to the programme, she didn't know much about digital marketing, social media marketing or the wide variety of business activities that could be handled with the help of digital platforms. That door was opened by the training. She got to know about digital tools and online business practices, digital payments, started transacting business through Paytm. She gained knowledge from her fellow students as well. Interviews with other female entrepreneurs gave her insights into various marketing methods, access to customers and business thinking. One of the concepts she had developed was the presentation and packaging of a product, as it becomes significant when a product is being exported out of the neighbourhood. The training was thus an extension of a skill that she already possessed. She knew how to bake. Now she knew how to think about the business side of the baking.



A Business Measured Not Only in Sales, but in Trust

Nishi produces several bakery items today, such as millet cookies, bread, pizza buns and pizza. Her millet cookies are sold at a cost of about ₹1,000 per kg and she has acquired over 100 loyal customers. Some customers come from as far as 50–60 kilometres away to purchase her products. This is a distance that matters. For Nishi, it's proof that customers aren't only purchasing a cookie. They're coming back for her product. In addition, she has purchased a commercial oven to make the goods at a larger scale. She sold cookies in excess of lakh in 1 year. This journey has been helped by her family. Her husband, children and family have assisted her in the selling and marketing of the products particularly as the business has expanded and she expresses that

“अपने हाथों से बनाई हुई चीज़ को बेचकर जो खुशी मिलती है, वह कहीं और नहीं मिलती।”

- The happiness of selling something that you have made yourself cannot be found anywhere else.

From Her Home to the President's House

From her humble kitchen, Nishi has come a long way in her entrepreneurial career. She has set up stalls in various events, and also sold her products at the President's House. She has sold the amount of about ₹5,000–₹10,000 at such stalls in a day. Being at a stall and selling the products she made herself to the top officials and visitors is a great transformation in her personal life for a woman who used to have no idea about how digital marketing can be used for business. She is proud if her products reach the high circles of officials and other distinguished customers. However, the most important acknowledgment is in a much simpler form. Nishi's work remains in people's minds when they see the cookies at stalls. Her cookie is no longer simply a product. It has become associated with her name. That, for her, is a different kind of success.



The Business Gave Her Something More Than Income

Nishi's work has not undergone as much change as her bakery. Has affected her independence. Now she makes a living from her own business. She gets to be generous with herself, her daughters and her family without asking for money. It has given them confidence because they are now financially independent. She is appreciated by her family. She has herself proved she can construct a thing. And she has started to dream of something even greater. Now her goal is to grow the bakery business, educate more women and eventually offer jobs through her bakery business. She doesn't want to hold the secret to herself. The women under her training and association have already started venturing out to set up shops and bakeries in various parts of the country like Delhi and Bihar. Her journey is thus spreading ripples. One woman acquired a talent. She trained another female. That woman began to work. Another business came into being.

The Next Challenge: Taking the Enterprise Further

Nishi knows what she would like to study next. She would like to be exposed to more value chain development and packaging opportunities as these would aid her to take the business to the next level. She also acknowledges that digital knowledge is one of the many obstacles for many women who have entrepreneurial potential. As she has seen, there are numerous women that have what it takes to be entrepreneurs and they are willing and have the potential to become one. They typically don't have digital knowledge or the confidence to apply it to business. This is where she believes a continued role for training schemes such as the one created at IIT Delhi. The first training wasn't the last of Nishi's learning for her. It made her want to do more research.



“हर महिला अपने घर और परिवार के लिए बहुत कुछ करती है। लेकिन अगर घर-परिवार की जिम्मेदारियाँ निभाते हुए वह थोड़ा-सा अपने लिए भी करना शुरू कर दे, तो धीरे-धीरे वही काम समाज के लिए भी एक बड़ा बदलाव ला सकता है। और इसके लिए कोई उम्र तय नहीं है। हम किसी भी उम्र में शुरुआत कर सकते हैं।”

-Every woman does so much for her home and family. But if, while fulfilling those responsibilities, she also starts doing something for herself, that small beginning can gradually create a larger change for society. And there is no fixed age to begin. We can start at any age.”

A Bakery Today- A Larger Enterprise Tomorrow.

Nishi's Story is still a work in progress. She believes her bakery needs to be expanded, it should be able to reach people all over the country, more of her customers should be women, she needs to enhance her packaging and value chain, and use the digital platforms to grow her market. Her dream is no longer limited to selling more cookies. It's about creating an enterprise that creates opportunities for others. What started as a skill that she taught others has turned into a program that propels her financial independence and encourages other women to think about becoming business owners. The biggest change for Nishi is that she doesn't have to wonder if she can begin. She's already begun. How far can this go now she questions. And her answer is simple—as far as she is willing to take it.



From One Woman's Skill to Many Women's Opportunities

The upswing of One Woman's Skill to Many Women's Opportunities. The purpose of the IIT Delhi project – “Empowering Micro-Level Women Entrepreneurship Through Financial & Digital Literacy” is manifested in Nishi's story. The training didn't make her skilful. She was already a winger. What it provided her was exposure to a different aspect of entrepreneurship—the part that related to digital tools, marketing, online deals, the formalization of business, and the way to access customers differently. And perhaps most importantly, it strengthened her confidence to see her existing ability as something that could become bigger. Her tale should serve as a reminder that sometimes, that's not the case with entrepreneurship and teaching a woman something new. At times, it involves making her see the economic value of her current knowledge. Then when that woman teaches another woman, the ripple effects are much greater than the original enterprise. A bakery can turn into a number of lives. A woman can be a trainer, and it is easy to turn her into one. One woman's start is another woman's start.